

Generic Systems Thinking & Design Project Framework – Project Activities and Deliverables Phase 1

Project Phase / Activity	Purpose	Key Activities / Methods	Expected Deliverables
1. Understand the System Context	Understand the problem as part of a larger system rather than as an isolated operational issue.	- Define the system boundary and context - Identify the system's purpose and intended outcomes - Identify visible symptoms and underlying issues - Identify key actors, institutions, processes, resources and constraints	System Context Brief containing system boundary, purpose, context, symptoms, constraints and initial problem framing
2. Identify & Map Stakeholders	Understand who participates in, influences, benefits from, or is affected by the system.	- Identify primary, secondary and indirect stakeholders - Map stakeholder interests, needs and expectations - Identify relationships, dependencies and conflicts - Identify formal and informal roles	Stakeholder Map showing actors, relationships, interests, dependencies and influence
3. Analyse Power, Interests & Leverage	Understand how differences in authority, resources, precedent and bargaining power influence system behaviour.	- Assess decision-making authority - Identify formal and informal power - Analyse stakeholder incentives and motivations - Identify who can influence decisions and who cannot - Examine unequal access to resources or opportunities	Stakeholder Power–Interest/Leverage Map and Power Analysis Brief
4. Trace the Existing Process	Understand how the system actually operates rather than how it is supposed to operate.	- Conduct interviews and observations - Trace decisions and interactions - Document formal and informal rules - Identify negotiation and escalation mechanisms - Track exceptions, workarounds and dependencies	Current-State Process Map / Process Trace showing actors, decisions, interactions, dependencies and exceptions
5. Analyse System Behaviour Over Time	Identify how individual decisions accumulate and create system-level outcomes.	- Collect historical versions, records or observations - Develop timelines - Identify significant changes and their triggers - Examine feedback loops and recurring patterns - Identify unintended consequences	System Timeline / Behaviour-Over-Time Map with key changes, triggers and emerging patterns

Deliverables:

1. System Context Brief
2. Stakeholder Map
3. Stakeholder Power & Interest/Leverage Map
4. Current-State Process Map / Process Trace
5. System Timeline / Behaviour-Over-Time Map

Generic Systems Thinking & Design Project Framework - Project Activities and Deliverables Phase 2

Project Phase / Activity	Purpose	Key Activities / Methods	Expected Deliverables
6. Develop a Rich Picture / System Map	Build a holistic representation of the system and its interconnected elements.	• Map actors, processes, information, resources and constraints • Identify conflicts and dependencies • Represent formal and informal structures • Highlight bottlenecks, tensions and feedback loops	Rich Picture / Causal or Systems Map representing the current system
7. Identify Systemic Patterns & Root Causes	Move from symptoms to underlying structures and mechanisms producing the problem.	• Distinguish events, patterns, structures and mental models • Identify reinforcing and balancing feedback loops • Analyse unintended consequences • Identify structural causes and systemic tensions	Systemic Problem Analysis identifying patterns, structures, feedback loops and root causes
8. Reframe the Problem	Convert an initial operational problem into a systemic design opportunity.	• Challenge initial assumptions • Compare stakeholder perspectives • Identify contradictions and tensions • Develop alternative problem framings • Validate the reframing with evidence	Reframed Systemic Problem Statement

Deliverables:

1. System Map
2. Causal Loop / Feedback Analysis
3. Systemic Problem Analysis
4. Reframed Systematic Problem Statement
5. Design Opportunity Statement

Generic Systems Thinking & Design Project Framework - Project Activities and Deliverables Phase 3 and 4

Project Phase / Activity	Purpose	Key Activities / Methods	Expected Deliverables
9. Define Design Principles & Intervention Opportunities	Identify where and how the system could be changed.	• Identify leverage points • Explore changes to rules, roles, incentives, information flows and processes • Develop design principles • Identify potential intervention points	Leverage-Point / System Intervention Map and Design Principles
10. Design, Test & Evaluate Interventions	Develop and assess interventions that improve system-level outcomes rather than optimizing one stakeholder's interests.	• Generate alternative interventions • Develop scenarios/prototypes • Simulate stakeholder responses • Test interventions against system objectives • Identify unintended consequences • Refine the intervention	System Intervention Prototype / Scenario Model, Evaluation Framework, and Recommended Intervention

Deliverables:

1. Leverage-Point / Intervention Map
2. Design Principles
3. Intervention Concepts / Prototypes
4. Scenario Model & Impact Evaluation
5. Final System Design Recommendation